

NewMaridEarthquaks+SecondGreatAwakening in TN

Script

In this video lecture, we're going to think about the new earthquake in 1811 and into 1812 and figure out why the historically significant why are they significant even today for people who are studying seismic activity and earthquakes and we think about how people in the past people who experienced these earthquakes and them from far away places did they understand your earthquakes now these earthquakes first there will be three major ones beginning in December December 2018 11 (1811) and continuing through February 18 12 (1812) and there will be hundreds of Moderate and thousands of small smaller earthquakes that will occur in the new Madrid region today. It is actually classified as the new Madrid size (seismic zone) so where the heck is that and if you're not familiar, it is pronounced new Madrid so it looks like Madrid but you say Madrid well the new Madrid seismic zone today it's classified is located in southeastern Missouri, Missouri southern Illinois Illinois. We also have right this extending into Northeastern, Arkansas, Arkansas western Kentucky, Kentucky, and Western Tennessee, Tennessee, which is why we're talking about it because it's irrelevant (relevant) for a Tennessee class and then in southeast southeastern corner of Missouri again 1811 December of that year continuing several months into 1812 this region is going to be rocked by a series of earthquakes some very big roughly around seven or eight on the Director skill (Richter scale) and then many other more moderate and smaller earthquakes will occur through this period of several months now these earthquakes are not like a lot of earthquakes that we might see where you have tectonic plates either grinding against each other or going like that if you can see my hands right where one plate is kind of being sued (subducted) by another. The earthquakes that happen in this region are intraplate and I'm a little little bit harder to understand in terms of the processes in terms of the seismic activity there may be a little bit more difficult to predict if I could generalize maybe grossly generalize that the science that and the complication surrounding plates, but none nonetheless right that is what's going to happen in 1811 and into 1812 these are going to be very very powerful specially the big ones and so if we had to think about those inter plates we could think about like a bowl of jelly shaking or a partially cooked casserole that's like wiggling a bit and the Earth is moving back-and-forth in that manner water in sand under the soil of the Mississippi Mississippi flood plane is going to respond by qualifying (liquefying) and it will turn into quicksand the liquefied sand will shoot upward in the wake of all of the seismic activity. This will create what it's called sand blows. Essentially these are volcano, rounded cones of white sand, and they will shoot up through these channels so this is as these earthquakes are occurring and you can see on the map here where exactly we have the big three earthquakes and then you can also see on this map some of the more recent seismic activity activity that in the region, these earthquakes were so powerful that a portion of western Kentucky will actually lurch upward. It will raise itself up into an enormous don't (dome) that uplift is still visible today, and as the legend has it, and this is in fact, true, the mighty Mississippi the Mississippi, Mississippi river did run backwards for a bit so this isn't many ways right indicative of how dramatic these earthquakes were in terms of the environmental havoc they will reek in that moment people will feel these earthquakes across the nation. People will feel them in places like New Hampshire, the Ohio Valley, and all over the East Coast. This is an event quite literally a great magnitude. In addition you'll have those earthquake cracks where it seemed like the Earth was swallowing homes and cows and engulfing them all into these new fissures made into the earths surface. We will also have caved in banks shared off forest and sunk land, which is a distinct feature, perhaps in the new Madrid seismic zone. We will also have the rising land from these earthquakes impound as you might know real foot (Reelfoot) creek, which will then

create real foot (Reelfoot) lake, which is in Tennessee Tennessee real foot (Reelfoot) lake as you might know is a shallow flooded forest and it's also one of the main fishing attractions in the western part of the state and it's a place to see some eagle potentially many people will experience this as I've said and they will write about it not that but it's going to inspire people on the ground to study these earthquakes and so you'll have in the early 1800s a lot of excitement from amateur scientist of a story (of a sort) who were determined to figure out what causes earthquakes and so that's among other interesting developments related to this that you have not only people who saw this as so significant, even if they experienced it on the East Coast or in New Hampshire, they will write about it, but also it inspired people to study earthquakes in the early 1800s of course they did not have the technologies that we have today but none of the right they will begin to embark upon a variety of studies to try to learn more about what makes these earthquakes happen, but as we've already talked about in this class, if we could just brought in our our view a bit further to this region more Generally the region of western Tennessee, Western Kentucky, Southeast Missouri, parts of Arkansas, Arkansas this whole region, where the new Madrid earthquakes occurs in 1811 and 1812 well it had a long then I kind of vibrant and dynamic region of settlements trading post and then a variety of indigenous communities and as historians have documented, these earthquakes are going to come at our kind of turbulence and critical time for Minh (many) indigenous communities in the region, including the Chinese Cherokees (the Cherokees) the creeks and indigenous communities will also respond to these these earthquakes. They experience them as well and because there were missionaries in the region, who were forging relationships with these indigenous communities we also have a better sense of what say some of the Cherokees, who had ventured out to western Tennessee to this broader region, where the earthquake occur we have a better sense of what these communities were thinking in the way of these earthquakes, generally speaking, indigenous people, people in the region, much as white settlers and traders in the region also thought the interpreted this these earthquakes as "powerful spiritual signs in the words of historian contentious (historian Conevery Bolton Valencius), and so to quote her from the upper Missouri river to the southeastern Woodlands Minh (many) Indians interpreted the quake as the calamus anger (calamitous anger) of the great spirit at the loss of Indian culture and Indian lands, the gave forced to (this gave rise to) three movements, political, and cultural Confederation led by the Shawnee Brothers, including Tecumseh, and then the religious revival amongst the Cherokee and civil and military military strike among the creeks through each of these movements I'm quoting native people's responded to disturbances in the Earth. I reassuring (reaffirming) relationships with tradition and land strained by American territorial and cultural pressures. I'll translate just a moment in each of these three movements Native American communities likewise created knowledge about the earthquakes as Americans were doing the same same in prayer, meetings, and revival, which will talk about Indian communities were also so busy interpreting these seismic disruptions through spiritual conversation and so one of the important differences, though there one of the important differences between some of the white settlers or traders in the region, who are also trying to wrap their heads around this Britain indigenous people people they will also seek to understand this, but the way they are trying to understand it most importantly, and this is the distinction here was that they were also kind of understanding the earthquakes through what was occurring particularly dislocation from the land that they had inhabited and through all of the Minh mechanisms that we've talked about through land session, treaty war, and so forth conflicts that land had been shipped away. This is in 18 teens. We're going to have some some other big land sessions as we talk about maybe a trickle saw we'll see this with the creeks as well so they're trying to understand these earthquakes these huge cataclysmic events and they're also viewing them through the lens of these other pressures this location, cultural pressures to assimilate, and so this is going to be our critical to how indigenous people understood these events and so as we will see you with the shiny (the) Cherokee will also interpret these

earthquakes as a kind of prophetic sign or symbol that you needed to resist Americanization, and also to resist the pressures of dislocation and so we have as I've said multiple indigenous groups trying to understand these earthquakes through some of the other events in their circumstances that were happening at the time for the Cherokee specifically the earthquakes will bring about a kind of spiritual fervor in the words of historian Conver Valent (Conevery Bolton Valencius). It was to quote her a compulsive wave of pathetic (prophetic), visions and community revival amongst the Cherokee this movement will begin in 1811 with communications two and (communion) with a great spirit and it will become much more intense after those earthquakes that occur so there was already could've been movement there the earthquakes occurred and this will heightened that sense that this is this is meaningful and so in community ritual and reliable (reveal) to quote the mini (many) Cherokee's fears of disruption in the natural world and disruption of spiritual community life-threatening identity church people some Cherokees will see this as apocalyptic is this the end of the world well, others will generally interpret this as a sign again to resist those pressures to be pushed further out and further out west to retain some of those court (core), traditions and rituals other other Cherokees understood the earthquakes and the sun are explained them this way that perhaps it's not a sign for us to change or for us to have some sort of a revival necessarily, but perhaps this is nearly (merely) a symbol of anger from the great spirit, two (directed at) white settlers who are encroaching upon our land and entering into this region and so that's another way that they will interpret series events for others in the region outside of the indigenous community, white settlers, and so forth, they will understand these earthquakes not through spiritual dimensions as well, but also the physical sensations by earthquakes so that the shaking the feeling like there's electricity kind of pulsating through your body from these trimmers among other things, the smells that will be unleashed from these earthquakes. This is all going to have an influence on the way that people know upon the way people understand these earthquakes and the meaning of them because people are constantly trying to extract meaning from these events among other things as I've said, they have sour smell that will fill the air, especially in the kind of epicenter of these earthquakes in 1811 and 1812 that stench of sulfur being unleashed from these events, we have a kind of special significance in the world of the early 19th century so what is going on with all these smell among other things some springs that people had used for drinking water will become essentially noxious after these earthquakes, they will start to foul with sulfur and no longer good drinking water. They could be used as a kind of medicine though to heal people so you'll be good to see healing strings (healing springs) in the week of these earthquakes, but that kind of characteristic rotten eggs of sulfur that comes from all of these logic events that are occurring in the week of these earthquakes, and at that moment, it suddenly made like whole area is reek of that smell of sulfur in that rotten egg. Why does all of this matter because this is occurring people are trying to understand this and it's meaning as I said so for some people who experience this firsthand 1811 1812 they will see this as a kind of terrifying roar of underground thunder that represented the threat of damnation to fearful Christians on the frontier of sorts, which would've been the new Madrid region at that time the devil smells of burning Sulfur, and so we can see from the new Madrid quakes, and how people wrote about them and recorded their experiences that they seem to understand this at least in some cases, as if this kind of represented through these sensory experience experiences a smells in the Earth shaking this seemed in some ways, kind of right threatened right hell it was you know beneath all of this and so this could potentially be interpreted in Asbury (as very) ominous but there's something else happening there as well the very physical sensation of the earth shaking for people at this time also tapped into what was occurring with the second grade (Second Great) awakening so what's going on there and what is it relationship to the new Madrid earthquakes well it's kind of summarize this very simply the second grade (Second Great) awakening will occur in the early 19th century the early 1800s and it is kind of loosely defined as suppose religious movement of sources in the

United States where you will see among other things, more emphasis upon personal salvation the emphasis upon being born again Christian, and you will also have a more emotional style, not only a preaching, but also of receiving those those servants and their responses that will become more socially and culturally acceptable so to attend I can't meeting or revival during the second grade awakening might mean that creature, sermon or minister sermon would move you to weeping to shouting to shaking to collapsing on the ground that like very physical manifestations of spiritual awakening or spiritual reflection, or sensations of obvious filled with the spirit quite literally and I'll offer some contacts and just just a minute about what's happening in Tennessee, but this also relates to the new Madrid earthquakes because as the Earth is shaking well this has a direct parallel to the shaking and the way that the spirit right the Holy Spirit kind of register in your body and so right as we're seeing the Earth, quite literally shape people's bodies. Well, they're also understanding this in some sense from this second grade awakening, and in western Tennessee and elsewhere in Tennessee are particularly an eastern Tennessee at this moment in places like Kentucky Kentucky you're going to have a number of Protestant denominations, including Methodist Baptist and Presbyterian Methodist will have perhaps the most influence initially in these revivals, we will see Baptist kind of pick up and also have quite a bit of influence and so what will happen is that in this region in Tennessee and Kentucky especially right around the early 1800s we will have Presbyterian's Methodist and Baptist begin to have each huge revivals and so you would have traveling preachers traveling ministers come in the Methodist Church circuit riders traveling ministers and they would set up these big revivals. They might last five days. He might have a big camp meeting where you could potentially have thousands of people some of the biggest ones were like 25,000 people gathered, and you would essentially have the great outdoors would be the church. Write your meeting outdoors that way you could accommodate all of these thousands of people you're camping and then you would have these you know these sermons these religious events essentially with a variety of things happening and I mean interestingly enough as attending these huge camp meetings if you had enough people there you also have people to get Mrs. (unclear — possibly "get married") not necessarily happening in like that in parts of Western Tennessee, but certainly places like eastern Tennessee in Kentucky at the time you would have people who were also maybe selling a bit of said too because there were so many people at these meetings that the ministers couldn't control everybody was there seen (the scene) might also have some whiskey dealers. You know some people who might eat practicing prostitution and so they might also attend these revivals trying to go to seduce people away from the other events that were happening there but none or less right this is going to get a sweep through Tennessee in the early 1800s and interestingly enough up until this point Tennessee and really had a reputation and this region had a reputation has not being very religious. In fact the inhabit (inhabitants) of the region had reputation for being mostly indifferent to religion, not attending church very often, but as a result of the second grade awakening suddenly we will see that change, and we will see the influence particularly of Methodism Baptist, grow considerably throughout Tennessee and the broader region has these quakes hit and they thrust people onto the ground, shakes their body shakes their homes in the land beneath them not surprisingly people would also interpret this in spiritual terms. Is this God on himself (God Himself), shaking the land, his hellfire, or threatening to erupt from the Earth through a sand blows through these great visions that might result not surprisingly again people would see this in spiritual terms. Finally people understood this through some of the emerging developments and science with domesticated forms of electricity through electric batteries, and so as they felt right the ground beneath them, they sometimes discussed this in the language of a kind of jolt quite literally from these earthquakes and so this will also intersect with people's experiences as well you know how do you understand this? Do you understand this in terms of some of the science that's emerging in the early 19th century or do you understand this in terms of religion and spirituality so we have these earthquakes

enormous historical significance in the early 1800s occur and then something curious happens over the course of the 19th century, Americans are going to largely forget about these earthquakes despite the fact that as I've said, we have a ton of evidence of their significance of the time and now we have lots of geologic evidence and environmental evidence of these earthquakes so we know they have a good sense of their Normandy (enormity), but for a variety of reasons if you want to know more about this, maybe one of my other classes in the future and and so for a variety of reasons, people begin to kind of forget about them to the point that scientist in the early 20th century, some of them doubted these earthquakes even happened and you'll have a few voices in the wilderness people who went back and studied an even recorded visual evidence of these earthquakes in the early 20th century, but there are right there's just not a lot of reception to these ideas. It's not until the 1970s when you have scientist at St. Louis university and also at the university of Memphis at our Institute (the Center for Earthquake Research and Information, CERI) that people began to or at least feel that it's important to study the seismic activity activity in the new magic (New Madrid) region and so this is going to revive interest in studying this region, studying the seismic activity and also in terms of appreciating again the historical significance and the geologic significance our mental significance of these earthquakes that occur occurred in 1811 and 1812 and one of the cool things is that the center for earthquake researching information information (Center for Earthquake Research and Information, CERI) at the university of Memphis would have a cool things that they actually have a historian on staff who studies account that people wrote from newspaper account to personal diaries journals and so forth at the time to try to map out the impact of these earthquakes and just the kind of generalized so we could see here from one of the maps produced by researchers that we where we have accounts and how many accounts we have from a variety of locations so they're doing really cool cutting edge work, but also they use historical evidence like you're doing in this class to study this past as well, so this is kind of cool right we we tend to think that in Stillfield (a STEM field) that history has no place but certainly with the Institute of at the University of Memphis we can see that that historical evidence has significance even for understanding this seismic zone today all right guys let's stop there. This was a long one I hope you got something valuable out of this. Let's move on some other subjects.

Summary

Lecture 6: The New Madrid Earthquakes & the Second Great Awakening in Tennessee — Entities, Relationships & Summary

1. Key Keyword Entities in Tennessee History

The New Madrid Earthquakes (1811–1812)

- **New Madrid Seismic Zone:** An intraplate fault zone (not a plate boundary) centered in southeastern Missouri and extending into southern Illinois, western Kentucky, western Tennessee, and northeastern Arkansas.
- **The "Big Three" Earthquakes (Dec. 1811–Feb. 1812):** A series of major earthquakes estimated at roughly magnitude 7–8 on the Richter scale, plus hundreds of moderate and thousands of smaller aftershocks over several months.
- **Sand Blows & Liquefaction:** Distinctive surface effects in which saturated soil liquefied under seismic stress, shooting liquefied sand upward through volcano-like cones.
- **Reelfoot Lake / Reelfoot Creek:** A shallow flooded forest in western Tennessee formed when the earthquakes caused land to sink and impound Reelfoot Creek; today a major regional fishing and

eagle-watching site.

- **The Mississippi River Reversal:** A legendary but historically documented effect in which the force of the earthquakes caused the Mississippi River to appear to run backward briefly.

Indigenous Interpretation & Historiography

- **Conevery Bolton Valencius:** Historian quoted describing indigenous and settler interpretations of the earthquakes as "powerful spiritual signs."
- **Tecumseh & the Shawnee Prophet (Tenskwatawa):** Led a political and cultural pan-Indian confederation movement that interpreted the earthquakes as a sign of the Great Spirit's anger at the loss of Indian lands and culture.
- **Cherokee Spiritual Revival:** A wave of prophetic visions and community revival among the Cherokee, beginning in 1811 and intensifying after the earthquakes, urging resistance to Americanization and dislocation.
- **Creek Civil Conflict:** Referenced alongside the Cherokee revival and Tecumseh's confederation as one of three parallel Native political/religious responses to the era's upheaval (a nod to the Red Stick/Creek War).

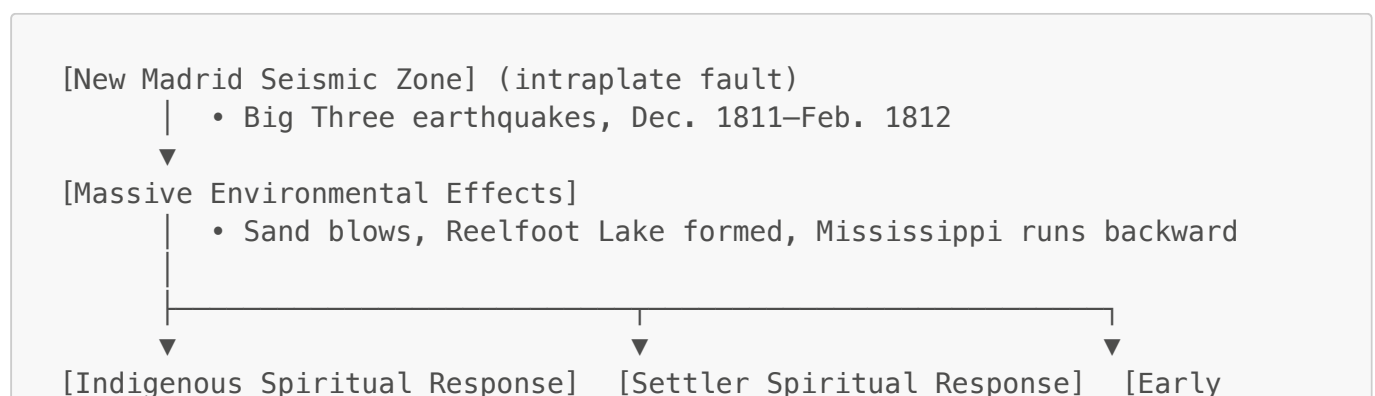
The Second Great Awakening

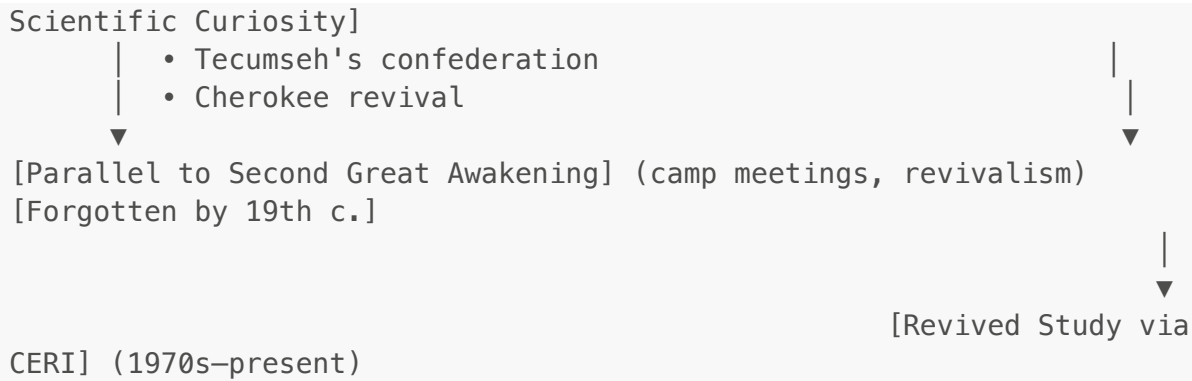
- **Second Great Awakening:** An early 19th-century religious revival movement emphasizing personal salvation, being "born again," and emotionally intense worship (weeping, shouting, shaking).
- **Camp Meetings & Circuit Riders:** Large outdoor religious gatherings (some drawing up to 25,000 people) organized by traveling Methodist, Baptist, and Presbyterian ministers, which transformed Tennessee's reputation from religiously indifferent to a hotbed of revivalism.
- **Spiritual vs. Scientific Interpretation:** The earthquakes' physical sensations (shaking, sulfur smells, "healing" springs) were interpreted by many contemporaries through the lens of religious revival occurring simultaneously.

Later Scientific Rediscovery

- **Center for Earthquake Research and Information (CERI), University of Memphis:** Along with scientists at St. Louis University, revived serious scientific and historical study of the New Madrid earthquakes starting in the 1970s, after decades in which Americans had largely forgotten — or even doubted — their significance.

2. Relationships Between Entities





Key Dynamics & Evolutionary Drivers

1. **Shared language of upheaval:** Indigenous communities and white settlers both reached for spiritual explanations of the earthquakes, but indigenous interpretations were filtered through the specific, concurrent pressure of land dispossession and forced assimilation.
2. **Coincidence of physical and spiritual shaking:** The literal shaking of the earth reinforced and amplified the emotionally physical worship style of the Second Great Awakening, which was already spreading through Tennessee and Kentucky at the same time.
3. **Memory and forgetting:** Despite enormous contemporary documentation, the New Madrid earthquakes faded from public memory over the 19th century, only being seriously re-examined by scientists and historians starting in the 1970s.

3. Lecture Summary

This lecture examines the 1811–1812 New Madrid earthquakes as both a geological event and a cultural moment, exploring how different communities interpreted the disaster and connecting it to the contemporaneous Second Great Awakening.

1. **The Earthquakes Themselves (Dec. 1811–Feb. 1812):** A series of powerful intraplate earthquakes, estimated at magnitude 7–8, struck the **New Madrid Seismic Zone**, an area spanning southeastern Missouri, southern Illinois, western Kentucky, and western Tennessee. The quakes caused dramatic environmental effects — liquefaction and sand blows, uplifted land forming visible domes, the apparent reversal of the Mississippi River, and the formation of **Reelfoot Lake** in western Tennessee — and were felt as far away as New Hampshire and the East Coast.
2. **Indigenous Interpretation:** Historian **Conevery Bolton Valencius**'s work shows that indigenous communities, already under severe pressure from land cessions and forced assimilation, interpreted the earthquakes as spiritual signs. This helped fuel three parallel movements: **Tecumseh** and the Shawnee Prophet's pan-Indian political-religious confederation, a prophetic revival among the **Cherokee**, and unrest among the Creek.
3. **Settler Interpretation and Scientific Curiosity:** White settlers and traders in the region likewise read the earthquakes in spiritual terms — as portents of damnation or divine anger — while also being among the first Americans to take up amateur scientific study of seismic activity, despite lacking modern technology.
4. **The Second Great Awakening:** The physical experience of the earth shaking dovetailed with the emotionally intense religious revivalism of the **Second Great Awakening**, which was sweeping Tennessee and Kentucky at the same time through Methodist, Baptist, and Presbyterian camp

meetings and circuit-riding preachers — transforming a region once seen as religiously indifferent into one of significant revival activity.

5. **Forgetting and Rediscovery:** Despite extensive contemporary documentation, the earthquakes' significance faded from American memory over the 19th century — some 20th-century scientists even doubted they had occurred — until researchers at St. Louis University and the University of Memphis's **Center for Earthquake Research and Information (CERI)** revived serious study of the region starting in the 1970s, combining geological and historical evidence.